

Metro 2033

Enthrallingly, eerily atmospheric – an adrenaline ride not to be missed

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Welcome to the future...

Post nuclear fallout, beneath a frozen, debris-ridden, irradiated wasteland, death is constantly one false step away. Humanity clings on; driven by perhaps the most primal instinct of them all – survival. Russia's underground rail system forms the ecosystem to which mankind clings tenaciously, for the surface is no longer inhabitable.

Into the Metro

While the stations remain safe, the tunnel system is anything but. Dangerous beasts lurk around corners, prowling around for what little game is at hand. The ambience is chilling, and Metro 2033 uses darkness to very good effect in this regard. Often, there is nothing more than the light of your headlamp and the greenish

glow exuded by odd radioactive fungi that flourish in certain parts of these dank tunnels. And the game can be unnerving at times; you'll hear snarls and expect to round the corner into a fight only to find an empty stretch. Suddenly, unexpectedly, a couple of creatures will rush you, while one pops up from behind a trash heap you dismissed as a part of the scenery. While your headlamp is pretty potent and goes a long way in exploring the derelict corridors of the Metro and even unearthing potential cover, it's also a dead giveaway, so you'll always be faced with a dilemma. The enemies range from prowling ravagers that use teeth and claws to smaller variants that employ nasty hit-and-run tactics to massive winged beasts, although the latter you will only encounter on the surface. There are human foes too, and these will often test your tactical skills, although they're seldom as hard to dispatch as the monsters, for the latter use speed and agility to great effect. Once in awhile, you'll emerge to the surface, in which case a gas mask is mandatory. Often, passing such levels is a test of speed, as you continuously hunt for gas filters for your mask – run out of these and it's a sure trip to your maker. Throughout the Metro, you'll pass through stations where you can

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Publisher: THQ

Developer: 4A Games

Platforms: PC, Xbox 360

Price: Rs 1,299

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sell off looted gear to hawkers for better weapons – the currency is pre-war ammunition! So you use rounds, to buy rounds, although the ones you'll use, pack less of a punch than the factory manufactured rounds. It's a matter of sheer quantity over quality.

Dilapidated beauty

Often you'll just stop, gaping in awe at the realism of your surroundings. On the surface, you'll spend time watching the play of moisture and gusts of wind on your gas mask. Underground too, the corona and particle effects generated by a campfire or lantern will enthrall you. Both light and the lack of it have been used exceptionally well to create a believable, riveting world. The textures, detail of weapons and environments are all pretty immaculate. If anything, facial expressions could have been worked on, but hey – it's not like you're going to be seeing many people anyway. Weapons have a nice impact to them giving combat a visceral feel. The audio component also dishes out atmosphere and realism in spades.

The single player campaign is long, Metro 2033 features a few DX11 tricks and the game engine is splendid. If you're wondering whether your 9800 GTX will do justice to the game, I suggest you upgrade. However, even if your system does not pass the buck – the gameplay alone justifies taking a ride on this Metro. **d**